Hiking Through Tamil Nadu's Enthralling Pathways

The Southern State offers a plethora of surprising treasures for hikers beyond the popular trails, including forts, treks, and nature camps, making it an intriguing destination for the upcoming holiday season.

From ancient forts to venerable walking paths and tranquil water bodies lying in the lap of nature, Tamil Nadu provides unalloyed delight to adventure seeking travellers. Here are some charming options for you to consider when planning a visit to the State.

VELLORE FORT

The most noteworthy features of the 16th-century Vellore Fort are its soaring ramparts and wide moat. When you visit, do check out the interesting structures in its premises. Uniquely , the fort houses a mosque, church and temple within its precincts, a luminous example of harmonious co-existence. The most impressive of these is the Jalagandeeswarar Temple, dedicated to Lord Shiva. The temple's gopuram (tower) is covered in intricate carvings. The Muthu Mandapam inside the fort is a pavilion in the Indo-Saracenic with gorgeous stained-glass windows and a museum. There's also Tipu Mahal, a two-storey palace where Tipu Sultan was imprisoned. The fort hosts a beautiful sound and light show in the evenings. Just 30 minutes away is the Lakshmi Narayani Golden Temple. Laced with 1,500 kg of gold, it's a sight to behold. You can also take leisurely walks in the Amirthi Forests, known for various flora and fauna. Vellore Fort is half an hour's drive from both Katpadi Junction railway station and Vellore airport. November to February is the best time to visit.

CAIRN HILLS

Blessed with sweeping mountain tracts, Tamil Nadu is a trekker's haven. One offbeat trail is Cairn Hills, lying 5 kms from Ooty via Lake Road. Once a tribal burial site, it was developed into an eco-tourism centre by the British in the 1860s. Today, it offers a tranquil ambience and a soulful 1.5-km-long trekking trail. The forest has an orchidarium, educational facility, and interpretation centre. The hanging bridge is a thrilling and enchanting experience. Trekkers can conclude their trip with the souvenir shop. A watchtower offers a 360-degree overview of the landscape. Admission for the guided trek is Rs 200, and the ideal start time is 9 am.

KALIKESAM

A 3-km-long guided trek takes visitors to the Kalikesam Waterfalls in Kanniyakumari District. The starting point of the trek is 3 kms from the Kalikesam bus stand and 22 kms from the nearest railway station. Lying inside the Keeriparai Sanctuary, the waterfalls on the Kalikesam River are a sight to behold. You might spot some elephants on the way. The watchtower at the endpoint is a major attraction for trekkers. Treks start at 9 am and no trekking is permitted after 3 pm. The entry fee is Rs 200. The Kalikesam Eco Camp on the banks of the Perunchani Dam offers overnight stays.It's best to avoid the rainy season as the water level may rise considerably.

GINGEE FORT

Gingee Fort is a grand, sprawling complex where the past comes alive through the remains of exquisite palaces and temples. The fort complex sits in the middle of three hills, Krishnagiri, Rajagiri and Chakklidurg, each with its own citadel. High walls running between the hills fortify the area. There is also an 80 feet wide moat, justifying Gingee's reputation as one of India's most impregnable forts. There is much to see here, including the seven-storeyed Kalyana mahal, Venkataramana Temple, Kali Temple and beautiful temple tanks. You can climb the different citadels independently and it's handy to have a vehicle to travel between the bases of the hills which are several kilometres apart. Krishnagiri offers an easy-to-moderate hike, while Rajagiri is the most challenging. December to March is the best time to visit.


Cairn Hills


Golden Temple


Gingee Fort

Few things bring as much joy as communing with the great outdoors. This time around, do give these trails a go.


Vellore Fort